The Prison Years

Honecker's experiences in captivity would change the trajectory of his life and in turn the lives of millions of others. The clandestine manner of his propaganda work provided sufficient evidence for a crime by the low standards of Nazi justice. However, nothing in his imagination, before entering Gestapo headquarters, had prepared him for the merciless, degrading misery of prison. The building on Prinz-Albrecht-Straße, which housed the office of Heinrich Himmler, sat above a sprawling complex of airless subterranean cells and interrogation rooms.

From this moment, there was a year and a half of struggle with the state advocate who, as Honecker explained, was sniffing for blood. 'He wanted to impute us to deeds that would warrant a death sentence. These are not my words, but those of my official defence, an SS leader.'1 Lack of information about proceedings and scant contact with friends and family contributed to his mental anguish. And although pre-trial detention provided time to dwell on what was to come, Honecker maintained that resistance to Hitler proved there 'was another Germany' and claimed to have helped 'convert' members of the Hitler Youth, Labour Front and the SA members to the anti-fascist cause.

Honecker's survival in the Nazi prison system is nothing short of incredible. During 1935–37 he endured a tough, miserable existence at three infamous Berlin prisons: Columbia-Haus, Moabit and Plotzensee – all desolate, impregnable and oppressive places. The latter, in the northwest of the city, was being used as a remand detention centre for political cases at the 'Special Courts' and the notorious 'People's Court'.

The sequence of events that followed could not have been more predictable. On the third of July 1937, the boyish-looking Honecker was escorted a few hundred meters past the famous Sports Palace (where Hitler made his big speeches) to the second floor of the old Kammergericht building in Kleistpark – later the scene of show trials under the fiery Nazi fanatic